

BUSINESS INTELLIGENCE OVERVIEW REPORT

Project: Sales Performance Dashboard – Global Superstore

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Introduction

This report is the first step of my Week 2 assignment. Before building anything in Power BI, I spent time understanding what business intelligence actually is, why companies rely on dashboards, and what this particular project is meant to achieve with the Global Superstore sales data.

What business intelligence means

When I first came across the term, I assumed "business intelligence" was the name of a software tool. It is not. BI is better described as a process: a company takes the data its operations already produce, in this case sales orders, then cleans it, analyses it, and presents it in a form that people can act on. The "intelligence" is the output, not the software. It is the difference between having an order file that nobody reads and knowing, for example, that heavily discounted Furniture orders consistently lose money.

In practice, BI sits between raw data and management. Tools like Power BI (which I am using for this project) handle the summarising and the presentation, but the goal is always the same: give the people running the business an honest, current picture of performance, so decisions are made from evidence instead of instinct.

Why organisations bother with dashboards

A dashboard is the most visible part of BI, and it is the part I will be building. The reason companies use them is simple. Managers do not have time to read an order file row by row, and spreadsheets are easy to break and hard to trust once copies start circulating by email.

A dashboard fixes this by keeping the numbers that matter, things like total sales, total profit, order count and profit margin, on one screen, all calculated from a single source. When a manager opens it, they are not looking at data; they are looking at the state of the business. If profit in one market drops, the dashboard shows it in the same week it happens, not at the end of the quarter when someone finally reconciles the spreadsheets. That early warning is, in my view, the main reason organisations invest in dashboards.

How dashboards actually change decisions

A few things stood out to me while researching this. First, visuals are faster to read than tables: a line chart of monthly sales shows seasonality in seconds, while the same conclusion can take minutes to dig out of a pivot table. Second, interactivity changes the conversation. With slicers for market, segment or category, a manager can ask "is this a Technology problem or an Africa market

problem?" and answer it themselves in two clicks, without waiting for an analyst. Third, and perhaps most importantly, a dashboard gives everyone the same numbers. Many business arguments are not really about strategy; they are about whose spreadsheet is correct. One shared dashboard removes that.

For Global Superstore, this means a question like "should we keep discounting products at 60–70%?" stops being an opinion and becomes something the data can answer.

The business objective of this project

The dataset I am working with is the Global Superstore order file, covering sales from 2011 to 2014 across markets in the US, Canada, EU, EMEA, APAC, LATAM and Africa. Each row is one order line and records who bought (Consumer, Corporate or Home Office), what was bought (Furniture, Office Supplies or Technology), where it shipped, and the financial result: sales, quantity, discount, profit and shipping cost.

My objective is to build a dashboard that answers the questions management would realistically ask of this data:

How is the business performing overall, in sales, profit, orders and margin?

Which markets and regions make the most money, and which only look busy?

Which customer segments and product categories drive revenue, and which individual products lose money?

How have sales and profit moved between 2011 and 2014?

Based on the answers, what should management change, especially around discounting and unprofitable products?

An early look at the data (notes for Part 2)

I opened the file and inspected it before writing this report, and a few things will need attention in Power Query. Order Date and Ship Date arrived as text in DD-MM-YYYY format, so I will convert them to proper date types. Postal Code is empty for almost every non-US order, which looks like a feature of the data rather than an error, so I will keep the column but not rely on it. A good number of orders show negative profit, and nearly all of them carry discounts of 60–80%; that is not a data problem, it is probably the most important business story in the file, and I plan to highlight it on the dashboard. Finally, a few city names contain odd characters from an encoding issue, which I will clean where practical.

With the objective clear, my next step is to load the data into Power BI and prepare it properly, which is Part 2 of this assignment.